

WEEK 14 DAY 2

Privacy Incident Detective

A fictional breach-response case where evidence matters more than panic.

**CASE
FILE**

Individual lab • no presentation • final project due May 26, 2026

TODAY'S GAME

You are not the firefighter. You are the detective.

**Evidence first.
Drama later.**

- What do we know?
- What is still unknown?
- What data is involved?
- Who could be harmed?
- What should happen next?

CORE CONCEPT

An incident is a security event that needs a decision

Event

Something happened: a file was shared, an account logged in, a database changed, or data moved.

Incident

The event may affect confidentiality, integrity, availability, privacy, or trust.

Response

People decide how to contain harm, preserve evidence, communicate, and prevent repeats.

SYLLABUS CONNECTION

This case pulls together the whole course

- Access control: who could open the file?
- Cloud security: how did sharing settings expose data?
- Databases: what fields were exported?
- Privacy and ethics: who could be affected?
- Governance: what rule should prevent the repeat?

CASE FILE

CampusQuest Rewards: a fictional cloud-sharing incident

- A student rewards app exported a CSV for dashboard testing
- The CSV was placed in cloud storage
- The file was accidentally made public by link
- A student found it online and emailed the help desk
- The link was disabled the next morning

THE DATA

Not all exposed fields create the same level of concern

Lower concern

Event points, app consent status, and major may seem ordinary but still need context.

Medium concern

Name, school email, last login date, and partial ID can identify or track people.

Higher concern

Free-text help notes can reveal sensitive needs, situations, or personal context.

DETECTIVE RULE 1

Separate confirmed facts from assumptions

A rumor is not evidence.

- Confirmed: the public CSV existed
- Confirmed: the link was disabled
- Unknown: who downloaded it and why
- Rumor: passwords were leaked
- Evidence: no password field appears in the CSV

DETECTIVE RULE 2

Build a timeline before deciding severity

- When was the public link created?
- When was it discovered?
- When was it disabled?
- How long was the exposure window?
- What happened before and after containment?

DETECTIVE RULE 3

Triage means deciding what deserves attention first

Sensitivity

What kind of data was exposed?

Exposure

How broadly was it available or downloaded?

Harm

What could happen to affected people?

FIRST HOUR

The first response should contain harm and preserve evidence

- Disable the public link
- Preserve logs and access records
- Identify exactly what fields were exposed
- Confirm whether rumors are supported
- Escalate to the privacy or legal contact

BAD MOVES

Some actions feel decisive but make the response worse

- Deleting logs destroys evidence
- Saying “nothing happened” before checking scope loses trust
- Saying “everything was hacked” exaggerates beyond evidence
- Resetting passwords may be unnecessary if passwords were not involved
- Blaming one intern hides process failures

PRIVACY LENS

The people affected are not just rows in the CSV

- Names and emails can identify students
- Login dates can reveal activity patterns
- Help notes can reveal sensitive needs
- Major and points can create profiling or embarrassment
- Communication should respect people, not just protect the institution

COMMUNICATION

A good incident update is clear, calm, and specific

Say what happened

Use plain language and confirmed facts.

Say what data was involved

Name categories without adding unsupported claims.

Say what happens next

Containment, review, contact point, and protective steps.

PREVENTION

The best fix is usually boring and procedural

- Private-by-default cloud storage
- Access review before sharing files
- Fake or minimized test data
- Remove free-text notes from exports
- Retention rule for temporary files
- Alerts for public links

PROFESSIONAL ANCHOR

Real guidance uses the same basic pattern

- NIST incident response guidance emphasizes preparation, detection, response, and recovery
- NIST Privacy Framework frames privacy as risk management
- FTC breach guidance highlights securing operations and notifying appropriate parties
- Today we practice the beginner version of those habits

TODAY'S LAB

Your job: solve the case file without overclaiming

- Mark facts vs. assumptions
- Classify the exposed fields
- Build the timeline
- Score severity
- Choose first-hour actions
- Write a plain-language update
- Pick prevention controls

MAKE IT USEFUL

If you finish early, connect the method to your final project

- What facts does my project actually prove?
- What assumptions should I avoid?
- What data or people could be harmed?
- What recommendation is realistic?
- What limitation should I admit?

EXIT TICKET

Before you leave: what did the evidence support?

**Facts. Harm.
Action. Prevention.**

- Most important confirmed fact
- Most dangerous rumor or assumption
- Strongest first-hour action
- Best prevention control
- One useful final-project connection